followed up with another two dozen aircraft that were flown by No. 42 Squadron.

By then, quite a few short, semi-prepared runways had been laid out by the Assam Rifles for which the DHC-3 Otter Aircraft was the best option; it would soon become the mainstay in the Lohit Frontier Division.

The C-113 seemed to be the frontrunner among heavy lift aircraft the country was looking to buy, until Krishna Menon decided to zero in on to the Soviet AN 12. The deal was signed in 1960, and the first batch of seven aircraft were ordered mainly to airlift heavy machinery for the Border Roads in Ladakh. However, during the initial trial runs the Soviet test pilots, after making the approach, refused to land at either Leh or Chushul, saying it was too risky. Squadron Leader Chandan Singh, who had converted to the aircraft by then, volunteered to take on the task with his crew. Chandan Singh was to later land the first AMX 13 tank at Chushul.

In addition to the AN 12 fleet, Super Constellations from Air India had also been transferred to the IAF fleet and were part of No. 6 Squadron. During October and November 1962, these aircraft clocked 1,000 hours in support of the army, ferrying entire battalions in addition to tons of sand bags and barbed wire.

The Bell-47G-2 light helicopter was the first rotor wing to be inducted into the IAF in 1954. Six Sikorsky S-55s followed shortly, as did Mi-4 helicopters in 1961. Most of the helicopter pilots were thrown into operation right from the moment the machines arrived and it is to the immense credit of the IAF that the helicopter crews performed superbly throughout. By the beginning of November 1962, the first Aloutte III helicopters had also started flying.

THE WILL TO FIGHT

Nehru, Menon, Mullik...these were the three personalities that most influenced events and shaped destiny that year but for those manning the bunkers on the night of 19 October 1962, they were of little relevance. Their officers and their respective COs meant a lot more. For the men, even the likes of Brigadier John Dalvi, the commander of 7 Brigade, and Major General Niranjan Prasad, the GOC of 4 Division, were too far removed from them to impact their fighting capabilities.

Field Marshal William Slim, who had fought the gruelling campaign against the Japanese in what were perhaps equally primitive conditions in